

THE BULLET AND BOMB ATTACK

Learning quickly from the failed Karachi attacks of October 18 which Benazir survived, terrorists moved in closer this time to attack her with a gunman and suicide bomber. If one failed, the other would strike.



She emerges through the SUV's sun roof to wave at the cheering crowds

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December 27, 2007. 5 p.m.

Bhutto finishes addressing rally in Rawalpindi's Liaquat Bagh, heads for her white armoured Toyota Landcruiser.



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Gunman fires AK47 burst at her, hitting her in throat and chest. She slumps into vehicle.

Pakistan's best chance to shake off General Pervez Musharraf's iron-fisted control of the government. To tilt the political balance back towards genuine democracy and get rid of the unpleasant label of The Most Dangerous Place On Earth. As the sun set over the garrison town of Rawalpindi and took Bhutto with it, all bets were off. After addressing a rally in Liaquat Bagh, two-time prime minister Bhutto, clad in purple rather than the customary campaign green, wearing fashionable glasses, garlands and her broadest smile, boarded her bulletproof white Toyota Landcruiser. Close to 50,000 people, including thousands of Pakistan Peoples' Party (PPP) loyalists, had heard Bhutto speak in the sprawling park. The Bagh, where the first Pakistani prime minister Liaquat Ali Khan was assassinated in 1951, already had a bloody history but no one seemed to remember. The crowd was ebullient, energised by Bhutto's election speech.

PPP workers, chanting slogans of "Prime minister Benazir Bhutto" surrounded her SUV, forcing the driver to bring it to a halt. Here, versions differ. According to one, Bhutto appeared through the sun-roof to wave at the crowds. According to another, a blast in the park made her look through the roof to see what had caused it. The moment she did that, it happened.

Less than five metres from the SUV, a thin, young man pulled out an AK47 and fired at her five times. Bhutto took a hit in the neck and the chest, and fell. As her startled security moved to act, the shooter, or someone close to him, blew himself up, killing 30 people and damaging her SUV further. Some reports say she lay dying for close to 10 minutes after that as people kept away from the vehicle fearing another blast. Her temple had been pierced, either by a bullet or by one of the ball bearings usually packed into a suicide belt.

She was rushed to the nearby semi-equipped Rawalpindi General Hospital in a critical condition and was declared dead at 6.16 p.m. local time. When a PPP official confirmed the worst half an hour later, saying, "Mohtarma has been martyred," a wail of anguish broke out from the crowd. It responded with anger, smashing the door to the emergency unit of the hospital and with the news, violence spread across Pakistan like a bloodstain.

Sitting inside the hospital in stunned silence was Sharif, former prime minister and Bhutto's most bitter political adversary. To Bhutto's grief-stricken supporters he said later, "Don't feel alone. I am with you. We will take revenge on the rulers." Sharif, recently barred for life from contesting elections, moved swiftly announcing that his party the Pakistan Muslim League would not contest the forthcoming elections, calling them, "meaningless."

Bhutto's assassination has sent the